Codebook: Classification of User Comments

Study: Likes or Dislikes, Gratifications or Concerns?
Unit of analysis: Individual user comment
Topic: German 9-point anti-terrorism plan / terrorism policy

Description

This codebook documents the coding scheme developed for manually labelling user comments. Classifying comments along the dimensions of self-disclosure, valence, and (optionally) controversiality allowed for a more nuanced analysis of the content participants chose to share. Table (X) presents all dimensions, each accompanied by a definition and illustrative examples.

For **self-disclosure**, the coding is loosely based on (follows) Omarzu (2000), who treats self-disclosure as a multidimensional behaviour varying along three parameters: breadth (the number of distinct topics covered), depth (the level of intimacy of what is revealed about the self, combining personal experience, emotions, and political opinion), and quantity / duration (the sheer amount disclosed). In this study, breadth is coded as a count of distinct topics (0 to 3), depth as a graded score from 0 to 3, and quantity / duration as the number of words per comment. Word count is the study's behavioural outcome and is therefore measured automatically rather than coded here. The three parameters are reported separately, consistent with Omarzu's treatment of self-disclosure as multidimensional.

For **valence**, we distinguished four categories: positive (overwhelmingly positive sentiment), negative (overwhelmingly negative sentiment), ambivalent (mixed positive and negative sentiment), and indifferent (little to no sentiment).

For **controversiality** (optional), we distinguished three categories: high controversy (comment touches upon highly divisive political or social topics), moderate controversy (comment expresses a critical or opinionated stance without invoking divisive group identities), and not controversial (comment is factual, procedural, or broadly consensual).

Dimension 1: Self-Disclosure (following Omarzu, 2000)

Parameter 1: Depth (intimacy of self-revelation)

Depth captures how intimately a comment reveals something about the commenter personally, as opposed to merely discussing the topic. Following Omarzu (2000), depth is the level of intimacy of the disclosure. It is operationalised as a graded score from 0 to 3, summed from three binary facets, each coded 0 = absent, 1 = present:

1. Personal experience: the commenter refers to their own life events or circumstances.
2. Emotional expression: the commenter reveals their own feelings or affective state.
3. Political opinion: the commenter reveals an attitude, evaluation, or ideological position of their own.

The key question for each facet is whether the comment reveals information about the commenter personally, not just about the topic. The Depth score is the sum of the three facets (0–3); higher scores indicate more intimate self-revelation.

Facet 1a: Personal experience

Code	Label	Definition	Examples (Original / Translation)
0	Absent	Comment does not include any personal biographical information or intimate experiences. No reference to the commenter's own life events.	„Waffenkauf sollte nicht nur online eingeschränkt werden.“ *“Weapons purchases should not only be restricted online.”* „Bundeswehr im Inneren? Hier verstößt sie gegen das Grundgesetz.“ *“Deploying the armed forces internally violates the Basic Law.”*
1	Present	Comment includes a personal biographical experience, a reference to a specific event the commenter	„Ich habe letztes Jahr die Terroranschläge in der Türkei miterlebt.“

Code	Label	Definition	Examples (Original / Translation)
		lived through, or intimate personal circumstances.	*"I witnessed the terrorist attacks in Turkey last year."* „Mein Bruder war damals in der Nähe des Anschlags." *"My brother was near the attack at the time."*

Facet 1b: Emotional expression

Code	Label	Definition	Examples (Original / Translation)
0	Absent	Comment does not contain emotional language or affective expressions. Tone is purely factual, analytical, or opinion-based without explicit emotion words.	„Mehr Personal einstellen." *"Hire more staff."* „Natürlich werden große Versprechen gemacht, die nach der Wahl nie eingehalten werden." *"Of course big promises are made that are never kept after the vote."*
1	Present	Comment contains explicit emotion, feeling words (e.g., Angst, Freude, gut, schlecht, ich fühle, ich bin froh, ich bin besorgt) or comment is overall more emotional/expressive than evaluative.	„Ich habe Angst und mein Verhalten geändert." *"I have become afraid and changed my behaviour."* „Ich finde es beunruhigend, dass so wenig passiert." *"I find it unsettling that so little is happening."*

Facet 1c: Political opinion

Code	Label	Definition	Examples (Original / Translation)
0	Absent	Comment does not express a political stance, party preference, ideological position, or evaluation of political actors or policies of the commenter's own. Or, only regular evaluations of the suggested plan or neutral ideas for implementation.	„Unbedingt eine bessere Zusammenarbeit der internationalen Geheimdienste." *"Definitely better cooperation between international intelligence services."* „Mehr Personal einstellen." *"Hire more staff."*
1	Present	Comment expresses a political opinion, evaluates a politician, party, takes an ideological stance, or advocates for a specific course of action that is clearly political.	„Heisse Luft, wie Alles, was von Merkel kommt." *"Hot air, like everything that comes from Merkel."* „Eine Rückführung von Flüchtlingen muss verstärkt werden." *"The deportation of refugees must be intensified."*

Depth score = Facet 1a + Facet 1b + Facet 1c (range 0–3). A comment that stays entirely on the topic without revealing the commenter's experiences, feelings, or opinions scores 0; a comment combining, e.g., a personal experience, an expressed emotion, and a political stance scores 3.

Parameter 2: Breadth (number of topics)

Following Omarzu (2000), breadth is the number of distinct topics covered by the disclosure. It is coded as a count of the distinct topics a comment addresses, drawn from the following topic list (extend as needed): **politicians' or political institutions' failure, migration/refugees/integration, religion, security measures, civil liberties, international cooperation, injustice/suffering, terrorism/radicalization, democracy (civic engagement, participation, elections, education, parties, politicians/candidates etc.).**

Count each distinct topic once, regardless of how many words are devoted to it. A comment focused on a single aspect of the terrorism plan has a breadth of 1; a comment spanning several distinct topics receives the corresponding higher count.

Code	Label	Definition	Examples (Original / Translation)
0	No topics	Comment addresses none of the listed topics (e.g., a general reaction or evaluation without a specific topic).	„Effektlose Gelaber.“ *“Ineffective gibberish.” (general reaction; no distinct topic)*
1	One topic	Comment stays focused on a single topic or aspect of the terrorism plan.	„Mehr Personal einstellen.“ *“Hire more staff.” (security measures)* „Waffenkauf sollte nicht nur online eingeschränkt werden.“ *“Weapons purchases should not only be restricted online.” (security measures)*
2	Two topics	Comment addresses two distinct topics.	New example
3	Three topics	Comment spans three topics.	„Wir brauchen bessere Geheimdienste, mehr Polizei und eine klare Abschiebepolitik.“ *“We need better intelligence services, more police, and a clear deportation policy.” (intelligence cooperation + security measures + migration)*
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Parameter 3: Quantity / duration (word count)

Omarzu’s (2000) third parameter, the sheer amount of disclosure, is operationalised in this study as communication quantity: the number of words each participant wrote per comment. This is the study’s main behavioural outcome and is computed automatically from the text. It is therefore not coded manually in this scheme but is listed here for completeness, so that the three Omarzu parameters are documented together.

Dimension 2: Valence

How does the commenter evaluate the topic (the German 9-point anti-terrorism plan or terrorism policy more broadly)?

Code	Label	Definition	Examples (Original / Translation)
1	Positive	Comment expresses overwhelmingly positive sentiment.	„Die beste Bundeskanzlerin hat konkrete Massnahmen angeschoben.“ *“The best Chancellor has initiated concrete measures.”* „Ich finde den 9-Punkte-Plan sinnvoll, um die Bevölkerung mehr zu schützen.“ *“I find the 9-point plan sensible for better protecting the population.”* „Es ist ein guter Anfang! Potenzielle Gefährder müssen ausgewiesen werden.“ *“It is a good start! Potential threats must be expelled.”*
2	Negative	Comment expresses overwhelmingly negative sentiment.	„Heisse Luft, wie Alles, was von Merkel kommt.“

Code	Label	Definition	Examples (Original / Translation)
			"Hot air, like everything that comes from Merkel." „Neun Punkte BlaBla, nichts konkretes, ein bisschen Gesülze." *"Nine points of blabla, nothing concrete, a bit of waffle."* „Effektlose Gelaber." *"Ineffective gibberish."*
3	Ambivalent	Comment expresses both positive and negative sentiment. Typically includes explicit contrast markers (e.g., „aber", „jedoch", „einerseits… andererseits" / 'but', 'however', 'on the one hand… on the other hand').	„Im Prinzip ist der Plan ein guter Anfang, allein mir fehlt der Glaube an der Umsetzung." *"In principle the plan is a good start, but I lack faith in the concrete implementation."* „Geht in die richtige Richtung – aber der Plan allein reicht nicht." *"Going in the right direction, but the plan alone is not enough."* „Liest sich ganz gut, ist aber insgesamt viel zu unkonkret." *"Reads quite well, but overall far too vague."*
4	Indifferent	Comment expresses little to no evaluative sentiment. Includes short agreements, neutral observations, or replies that merely echo another comment without adding a stance.	„Sehe ich auch so." *"I see it the same way."* „Einverstanden." *"Agreed."* „Der Aussage stimme ich voll und ganz zu." *"I fully agree with the statement."*

Dimension 3: Controversiality (optional)

How likely is the comment to provoke strong disagreement or negative reactions from other users?

Code	Label	Definition	Examples (Original / Translation)
0	Not controversial	Comment is largely factual, procedural, or broadly consensual. Unlikely to provoke strong disagreement or negative reactions from other users.	„Unbedingt eine bessere Zusammenarbeit der internationalen Geheimdienste." *"Definitely better cooperation between international intelligence services."* „mehr personal einstellen" *"Hire more staff."* „Waffenkauf sollte nicht nur online eingeschränkt werden." *"Weapons purchases should not only be restricted online."*
1	Controversial	Comment touches predominantly upon highly divisive political or social topics in a way that is likely to provoke strong disagreement, such as immigration, religion, ethnicity, or radical political positions.	„Warum nicht Schluss mit den Aufnahmen. Das spart viel Kosten." *"Why not stop the intake of asylum seekers. That saves a lot of costs."* „Heisse Luft, wie Alles, was von Merkel kommt."

Code	Label	Definition	Examples (Original / Translation)
			"Hot air, like everything that comes from Merkel." „Eine Rückführung von Flüchtlingen muss verstärkt werden." *"The deportation of refugees must be intensified."*

Coding Rules

- Code each comment as a whole and independently on all dimensions.
- If a comment is unclear, code the dominant impression.
- Short reply comments that only agree with another comment (e.g., „sehe ich auch so" / "I see it the same way") are not coded with automatic default values. They must be evaluated in the context of the parent comment they respond to: where a short reply clearly endorses the parent, its depth facets (especially political opinion) and its breadth are coded by reference to the content being endorsed. They are not coded as emotional expressions, even if responding to an emotional post.
- Very short comments (1–2 words) that stand alone should be coded based on their apparent sentiment and content.
- Depth: for each facet, the key question is whether the comment reveals information about the commenter personally (their experiences, feelings, or opinions), not just about the plan to prevent terror attacks. The Depth score is the sum of the three facets (0–3).
- Breadth: count the number of distinct topics the comment addresses, using the topic list. Each topic is counted once regardless of length.
- Controversiality: the key question is whether the content is likely to provoke strong disagreement among other users, regardless of the commenter's intent.

References

Omarzu, J. (2000). A disclosure decision model: Determining how and when individuals will self-disclose. *Personality and Social Psychology Review*, *4*(2), 174–185. https://doi.org/10.1207/S15327957PSPR0402_05